



Most of what remains of the Great Wall of China was rebuilt during the Ming dynasty. Dotted with fortifications it extends over 4,000 miles (6,400 km).

IN 1483, THE WARS OF THE ROSES

flared up again (see 1454–55). Fought between Lancastrians and Yorkists—rival **Plantagenet** claimants to the English throne—it had appeared to have been settled for good in 1471. In 1470, the **Yorkist Edward IV**, who had seized the throne from the hapless **Lancastrian Henry VI** in 1461, had been forced from it by a group of vengeful magnates. In 1471, with **Burgundian support** from Charles the Bold (see 1472–76), Edward retook the throne. Henry was murdered, probably on Edward's orders.

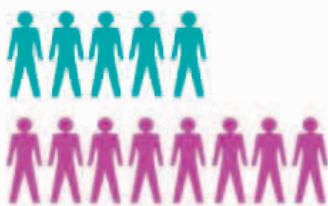
In 1483, Edward, now grossly corpulent, died. Instantly, the conflict reignited, albeit in a different form. The problem was that the new king, **Edward V**, was only 12 years old and his mother's family, the **Woodvilles**, saw the boy-king as an obvious opportunity to proclaim themselves regents—in effect, to seize the throne themselves, undoing Edward IV's legacy. This at least was the view of the dead king's most consistent champion, his brother the **Duke of Gloucester**, who was competent, intelligent, and loyal. Gloucester characteristically preempted the Woodvilles by seizing the throne himself, as **Richard III**, executing the leading Woodvilles, and **imprisoning Edward V** with his younger brother in the **Tower of London** where both were then murdered. If no definitive proof has ever been offered that Richard III was responsible for the deaths of his nephews, the overwhelming

THE RENAISSANCE



The Renaissance (literally “rebirth”) grew out of the Italian Middle Ages and marked a reevaluation of European thought. At its heart was a reinterpretation of Europe's Classical past. It gave rise, first in Florence (left), to an artistic and architectural revolution, and later, to a scientific one. Its early impact was fitful but eventually spread to most of Europe in the following 200 years.

probability is that **he ordered their killings**; his hold on the throne was too shaky to permit any rivals to survive if he could eliminate them. Richard III was vilified in later Tudor propaganda. But given the turbulent treachery of late-medieval England, Richard's actions seem fairly rational. Sooner or later the Woodvilles would have sought an excuse for his death.



5:8 **Battle of Bosworth**
Henry's Tudor army of 5,000 troops overcame Richard III's much larger force, which was undermined by poor leadership.

But there was a further **Lancastrian claimant, Henry Tudor** (1457–1509). His right to the throne was tenuous at best, but critically he had the support of the French king, **Charles VIII** (r. 1483–98). In August 1485, Henry led an invasion from France. By the end of the month, Richard was dead, killed at the **Battle of Bosworth**, his superiority in numbers undone by the ineptitude of many of his commanders. Henry Tudor, in turn, crowned on the field of the battle, had become **Henry VII**. The Tudor monarch's seizure of the throne might easily have provoked yet another round in this destabilizing infighting. But Henry VII would prove among the most pragmatic, capable, and far-sighted of kings. Under the Tudors, England was significantly strengthened, its magnates tamed, and its government comprehensively overhauled.

FOLLOWING ON FROM EARLIER PORTUGUESE VOYAGES (see 1470–71), two further expeditions were despatched in 1487 to investigate routes to and across the Indian Ocean. **Pêro da Covilhã** was charged with investigating the East African coast as well as the Indian Ocean. From Aden, reached via the Red Sea, he sailed to Calicut in India, as far south as Sofala in **East Africa**, and north to the Strait of Hormuz in the Persian

Gulf, reporting favorably on all these routes in 1492. The second expedition, under **Bartolomeu Dias**, was specifically charged with finding a navigable passage around the presumed southern tip of Africa. In January 1488, rather than simply following the African coast southward as **Cão** and others before him had done, at around 27°S (several hundred miles short of the tip of south Africa) he headed southwest, away from the coast. By any measure, that was remarkably daring. Miles from land, he picked up the westerlies that blow in the South Atlantic and was carried almost 300 miles (500 km) to the east of the **Cape of Good Hope** on the tip of southern Africa. Dias's voyage provided a better understanding of the wind systems that linked the Atlantic and Indian oceans, and proved vital in calculating the route to the Cape of Good Hope and beyond. Later, **Vasco da Gama** and **Pedro Cabral** exploited this knowledge in their own voyages.

Human sacrifice is a feature common to many early societies.

20,000

THE ESTIMATED NUMBER OF PEOPLE SACRIFICED AT THE INAUGURATION OF THE TENOCHTITLAN PYRAMID

